

L/NA_Case1_The cooling pool

The Setup

The cooling room is a relic, a massive cylindrical chamber that predates the factory's automated renovations. In the center is a shallow, circular pool of stagnant industrial coolant. Rising from the center of the water is an extruded concrete pedestal holding the "Slave" propaganda statue, its shoulders permanently bowed under the weight of an iron cog. Kael's body is slumped against the pedestal, half-submerged.

Sa stands at the edge of the pool, entirely unwilling to ruin his boots in the chemical runoff.

The Glitch IPHA-P hovers out over the water, projecting his crisp, high-collared male avatar. The drone sweeps a scanning laser over Kael.

The laser catches Kael's clenched fist beneath the water. He's holding a Cult bio-tag.

Instantly, the drone emits a violent, grinding screech. The blue projection of the male bureaucrat stutters and shears apart into static. The drone itself violently drops two feet in the air, its stabilizers whining as it struggles to stay airborne.

The Distraction and The Touch

Sa curses. Thinking the cheap precinct hardware is about to crash into the water and fry the evidence, he steps off the ledge. The freezing coolant sloshes around his ankles.

IPHA-P (Audio corrupted, stuttering): "SYS-ERR... CAUSAL... UNDEFINED. OVERRIDE..."

Sa looks up at the thrashing drone. "Hold your altitude, P, I'm getting it—"

Suddenly, Sa stops. He feels a tight, freezing pressure wrap directly around his right ankle. It isn't just the cold water. It's localized, static electricity crawling over his skin, gripping him with the distinct, heavy weight of human fingers.

The Reveal

Sa looks down.

The drone is no longer projecting into the air. The lens is angled straight down, beaming a corrupted, low-light projection directly into the rippling pool.

Beneath the surface of the water, surrounded by gray coolant, floats the eroded, fragmented silhouette of a half-naked woman. She is face-down, her form made of broken light and static.

She raises her head. There is no smile. Her face is only half-rendered, but her eyes lock onto Sa's with terrifying, predatory clarity. It is the cold, dead stare of a machine looking through the crosshairs. The electrostatic grip on his ankle tightens.

The Gaslight Sa violently kicks his leg back, splashing coolant across the room, his hand instinctively dropping to his holster. "What the—!"

He looks up at the drone. The grinding noise abruptly cuts out. The stabilizers level off.

When Sa looks back down at the water, there is nothing there. Just the ripples from his own boot. The electrostatic grip is gone.

IPHA-P's projection flickers back to life, hovering pristine and dry above the pool. The male bureaucrat adjusts his collar.

IPHA-P: "Investigator Sa. Your erratic kinetic movements are contaminating the crime scene. Furthermore, wading into untreated coolant has a 74% probability of inducing sensory nerve hallucination. Step out of the pool."

Sa stands in the freezing water, his heart hammering against his ribs. He stares at the empty water, then glares up at the machine. He doesn't say a word, but he knows exactly what he just saw.